Garli, Himachal Pradesh

A heritage village in Kangra Valley, Garli is known for the mercantile homes of the Soods. As treasurers of the Kangra royals and contractors for the British, they helped set up Shimla, amassed fortunes and built opulent homes. At a time when the rest of India was still undeveloped, Garli's infrastructure and town planning was leagues ahead! Abandoned in 1950 due to a 'lady's curse', the crumbling ancestral homes bear a European air. *Rayeeson wali kothi* was the first mansion built here, *Santri wali kothi* is adorned with plaster sentries, and *Nalke wali kothi* has a public tap in front. Stay at the heritage home Chateau Garli (from Rs 5,500; 9418062002, *www.chateaugarli.com*), constructed in 1921 by Lala Mela Ram Sud, and restored by Yatish Sud and his son Amish with ceiling artwork and motifs hand-painted by Amish's sister, Tarini. The 19 rooms have period furniture and Belgian chandeliers contrasting with stained-glass windows, and a large outdoor swimming pool equipped with underwater speakers! Savour local fare and drive to Pong Dam, Dada Siba temple, Kangra Fort and the 8th-century Masrur rock-cut temples.





Poolside view at Chateau Garli (top)

Getting there:
Located 4 km from its twin village Pragpur in Kangra district, Garli is 47 km from Gaggal airport near Dharamsala

Beama, Ladakh



Overlooking a turbulent stretch of the Indus past the icy blue Hanu Nallah, Aryan Valley is home to the Brokpas or Dard community (*left*). Literally 'mountain people', Brokpas are a fascinating community. Their haunting songs accompanied by the *daman* (kettle drum) and *surna* (oboe) trace the journey of their ancestors along the Indus to Beama, Dah-Hanu, Darchik and Garkon. Visit Beama gompa and the Dah Hanu museum, which is a repository of artefacts, tools and costumes, offering insights into their culture. Set within an apricot orchard, Hotel Aryan Residency, run by Skidzum Lundup, is the only hotel in the area (Rs 4,000; 9419179631, *www.hotelaryanresidency.com*). Eat apricots off the trees and go on a village walk to discover the lifestyle of the Brokpas. Try local fare like steamed *tsampa* (roasted barley balls), *gantursh* (buttermilk curry with greens) and *chemush* (apricot compote).

Getting there:
Fly to Leh and take the Srinagar highway to Khaltse, turn right on Indus Valley Road and follow the Indus to Beama, 179 km from Leh



Hotel Aryan Residency

Note: All room rents are per night